

ETHIOPIA Food Security Outlook

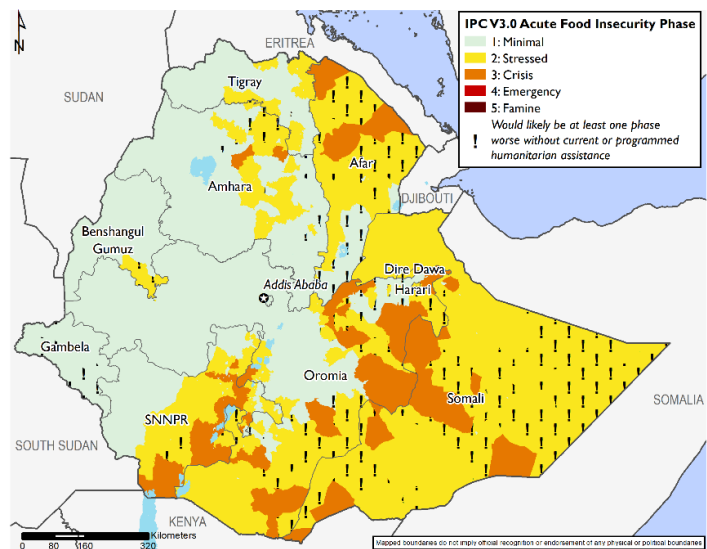
February to September 2020

Conflict, localized poor harvests, and desert locust will likely lead to Crisis (IPC Phase 3) in some areas

KEY MESSAGES

- Food security continues to be of concern due to flooding, protracted impacts of past poor seasons, conflict and insecurity, desert locusts, and poor macroeconomic factors, despite the favorable 2019 *Kiremt* and *Deyr* seasons. Poor household income and food access from livestock and labor has declined in parts of the country while food prices remain atypically high. As a result, much of the eastern part of the country is expected to be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) or Stressed (IPC Phase 2) from February to September. Humanitarian assistance is expected to improve outcomes in some areas to Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!) and Minimal! (IPC Phase 1!).
- The impact of desert locusts on crops and pasture has been localized with relatively minor crop and pasture losses. However, the ongoing desert locust upsurge in the lowlands of northern, eastern, and southeastern areas continue to threaten both crops and pasture. Crop losses in *belg*-dependent areas are expected to be locally significant although have little impact on national production. In pastoral areas, some pasture losses are expected. Although, the above-average pasture from the *Gu/Genna* season will most likely mitigate impacts during the dry season in southern and southeastern pastoral areas.
- Conflict, insecurity, ethnic violence, and the clash between state and non-state actors across the country, specifically in western and southern Oromia continue. This is increasing the loss of lives and livelihoods and displacement. Displaced households have difficulty accessing incomes and food and in some cases humanitarian assistance. These conditions are expected to continue throughout the scenario period and further increase as the August elections approach.
- Despite average national production, staple food prices across much of the country are atypically increasing, including in central and western surplus-producing areas. Staple food prices are anticipated to continue increasing as the lean season approaches and the election period begins. Conflict is expected to disrupt the movement of food from surplus producing areas to deficit areas. As labor rates are not expected to keep pace with price increases, household purchasing power is expected to further deteriorate.

Current food security outcomes, February 2020



Source: FEWS NET

FEWS NET classification is IPC-compatible. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners.

Desert locust upsurge expected to have localized impacts on pasture and the Belg harvest

According to FAO, desert locust bands and swarms are present in much of Somali Region, the Rift Valley, and southern SNNP and Oromia Regions along the Kenya and Somalia border affecting 180 woredas (Figure 1). The first desert locust swarm arrived in July/August 2019 from Yemen, where eggs hatched in Afar Region and spread into Eritrea. Based on information from the Ministry of Agriculture (MoA) and FEWS NET field assessments, the second swarm originated from Somalia and Djibouti and migrated into Somali Region in November 2019. Desert locusts then spread across much of Somali Region and into southern Oromia and areas of SNNPR. Desert locust impacts have been localized with no large-scale impacts on pasture, crop production, and livelihoods to date.

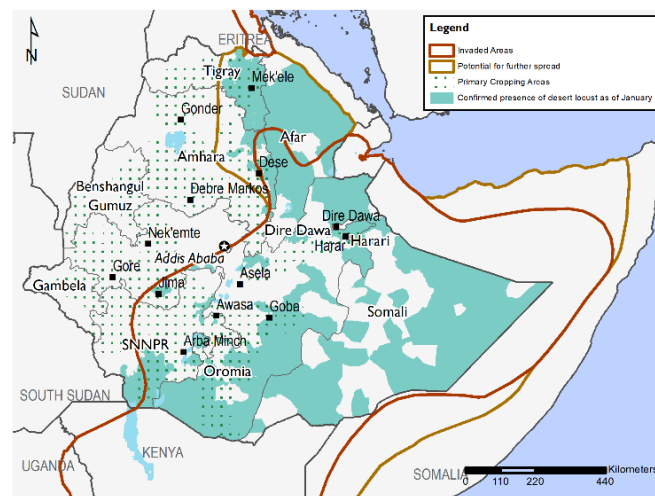
It is currently the dry season over much of Ethiopia and locusts are laying eggs and breeding across areas of Somali, Afar, eastern lowlands of Amhara, Oromia, and SNNPR, including the Rift Valley. Control measures are ongoing through aerial and ground spraying. However, they are mostly concentrated in areas of highest concern in southern areas but have been insufficient to contain any further spread of locusts.

In the **most likely scenario**¹, the desert locust upsurge² is expected to continue spreading due to favorable agroclimatic conditions despite the existing level of control measures, specifically, in the lowlands of Somali, rift valley areas of SNNP, and Oromia Regions. The swarms are expected to be pushed northward from Kenya back to Ethiopia with a shift in the winds. According to FAO, a new wave of breeding is anticipated for March and April. The western highlands are not expected to be affected since temperatures and vegetation are not conducive for locusts. Localized damage to crops is expected in some areas; however, the national *Belg* harvest is expected to be average due to favorable conditions. In areas worst-affected by locusts, the harvest is expected to be below average, negatively impacting household access to income and own production in *Belg*-dependent areas. In southern and eastern pastoral and agropastoral areas, pasture is likely to be above average, helping to mitigate desert locust impacts as some pasture will likely be available for livestock consumption. However, in worst-affected areas where desert locusts are most concentrated, atypical pasture deterioration is expected during the June to September dry season. As a result, livestock body conditions, and productivity is likely to be affected after the 2020 *Gu/Genna*, in particular in southern and southeastern lowland areas.

The locust outbreak is not anticipated to be contained through June 2020 and will likely continue spreading with the start of *Kiremt* rainfall to areas where conditions are favorable to desert locusts. Crisis (IPC Phase 3) and Stressed (IPC Phase 2) outcomes are expected to continue in some areas, specifically lowland areas, of SNNP, Oromia, Amhara, Afar, and Somali Regions, and the eastern escarpment of Tigray in June to September. These food security outcomes are anticipated to continue due to the compounding effects of continued drought recovery anticipated atypically high food prices, conflict-related displacement, weather hazards, macroeconomic challenges, and desert locusts.

In a **worst-case scenario**, desert locusts would invade a larger extent of lowland and main cropping areas due to high temperatures. Additionally, *Gu/Genna* would fail allowing for more widespread locust breeding and movement of large concentrated swarms across the eastern half of Ethiopia, including some surplus producing areas of the country. Locusts would also be pushed into north and northeastern areas of the country from the Red Sea catchment. This would result in below-average national *Belg* production, restricting cereal supplies, and further price increases across the country in an already tight market. In pastoral and agropastoral areas, pasture availability would deteriorate atypically early, leading to atypical livestock migration and excess livestock selling in worst-affected areas. Food security outcomes would deteriorate and result in an increase the number of people in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) or worse, specifically in Somali, and lowland areas of SNNP, Oromia, Afar and Amhara Regions and eastern escarpment of Tigray.

Figure 1. Location and spread of Desert Locusts for July 2019 to March 2020 and confirmed desert locust location



Source: FEWS NET/FAO/USGS

¹ For more detailed assumptions on FEWS NET's most likely scenario for desert locusts please see the assumptions section of this report.

² An upsurge per FAO, is when an outbreak or contemporaneous outbreaks are not controlled and if widespread or unusually heavy rains fall in adjacent areas, several successive seasons of breeding can occur that causes further hopper band and adult swarm formation and generally affects an entire region.

NATIONAL OVERVIEW

Current Situation

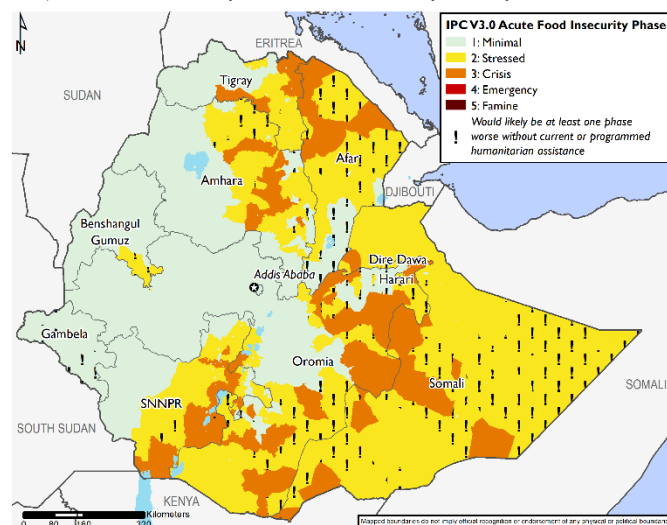
According to the Ethiopian Central Statistical Agency (CSA), national 2019/20 *Meher* crop production is estimated to be nearly 33.0 million metric tons (MT), which is about 12.0 percent above the four-year average. The increase in main season production is attributed to the favorable performance of the 2019 *Kiremt* rainy season and an increase in the area planted. Despite the favorable national *Meher* harvest, production was below average in most parts of eastern and southern Tigray, eastern and Waghimera Zone of Amhara, and eastern Oromia, particularly in East and West Hararghe Zones, and lowland areas of Arsi and Bale, bordering Somali region.

Performance of rainfall for the October to December 2019 *Deyr/Hagaya* was significantly above average, which was among the wettest *Deyr/Hagaya* seasons on record (Figure 2). The extension of 2019 *Kiremt* rainfall, across much of the country, resulted in crop damage in some mid and higher elevated areas and flooding particularly in Somali Region. This resulted in some crop and livestock losses, damage of water points and school facilities, bridges, and displacement of around 14,000 people. On the other hand, the continued rainfall improved pasture and water availability in most southern and southeastern pastoral and agropastoral areas. In agropastoral areas, households that were able to replant, harvested crops slightly later than normal and production is estimated to be below average. This is mostly due to consecutive flooding events, which prevented households from replanting and in other areas poor household's ability to access seeds for multiple plantings. The improved pasture and water availability improved livestock body conditions and productivity, particularly in areas that had a poor 2019 *Gu/Genna* season.

Despite desert locusts in southern and southeastern parts of the country, livestock body conditions are generally good due to the improvements and above-average availability of pasture and water. Desert locusts have only had localized impacts on current pasture conditions. Livestock migration is occurring normally across most southern and southeastern areas. Although, conflict along the Somali/Oromia border is restricting pastoral movements. This is forcing most livestock to a few areas where livestock are highly concentrated, resulting in pasture and water shortages. Livestock holdings in southern and southeastern areas are gradually improving; however, remain below average as pastoralists are still recovering from the 2015/16 drought. Livestock conceptions, production, and productivity have improved although continue at below average rates in these areas.

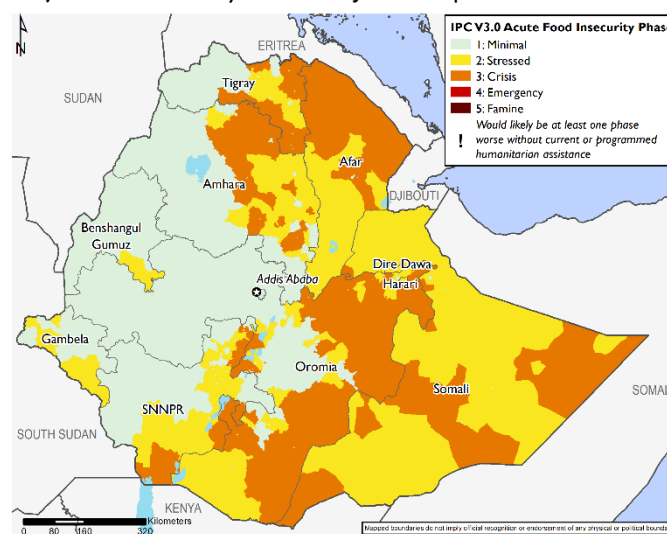
Meanwhile, much of Afar and Sitti Zone in Somali Region (which is seasonally similar to northern pastoral areas) has experienced three consecutive years of poor rainfall. Additionally, many far northern areas Afar did not experience an extension of the 2019 *Karan/Kiremt* season. Across much of this area, pasture conditions are generally below the median per the Normalized Difference Vegetation Index (NDVI) as of the February 21 to 29 period (Figure 3). As a result, livestock body conditions have started to deteriorate in northern Afar and Waghimera zone of Amhara. Key informants indicate atypical

Projected food security outcomes, February to May 2020



Source: FEWS NET

Projected food security outcomes, June to September 2020



Source: FEWS NET

FEWS NET classification is IPC-compatible. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners.

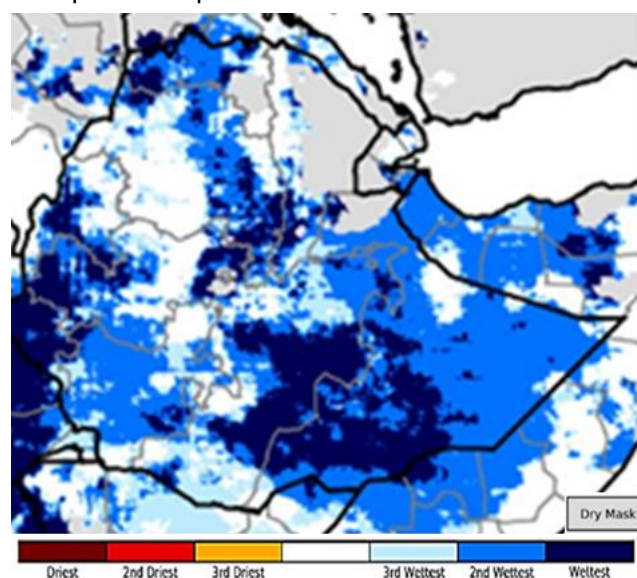
livestock migration occurring, especially in Zone 2, as there is little pasture in typical grazing areas. Some households have moved their livestock to bordering areas of Tigray to access pasture and water. Camel and goat birthing rates are slightly below normal. Though, milk yield per animal is near normal in most areas; however, total milk production for human consumption is below average due to below normal herd sizes. Access to food and income from the sale of livestock and livestock products is below average, which is restricting pastoral household purchasing power.

Belg 2020 rainfall has started in southwestern parts of the country. Rainfall has been favorable and slightly above average in SNNPR; however, there are some slight early season deficits in eastern and central Oromia and eastern Amhara. In *Belg*-receiving areas of the country, land preparation and some early season planting is underway. With the start of the *Belg* and the emergence of vegetation, which desert locusts favor for multiplication, formation, and spread of desert locust groups and bands are likely ongoing, especially in lowland parts of these areas. As of March 5, according to FAO, control measures are ongoing with slightly over 41,000 hectares treated since measures started being implemented.

Ethiopia's inflation rate has been increasing since late 2018 peaking in February 2020 at nearly 21 percent. In February 2020, the consumer price index (CPI) indicated year on year inflation was 21.8 percent, this is a significant increase in the inflation rate from 18.7 percent in January (Figure 3). According to the National Bank of Ethiopia, the high rate of inflation is due to the widening balance of trade mainly from infrastructural developments, among others, amidst a reduction in international reserves and liquidity. This is resulting in the depreciation of the Ethiopia Birr (ETB), and higher prices of imports for fuel, spare parts, food, and agriculture inputs.

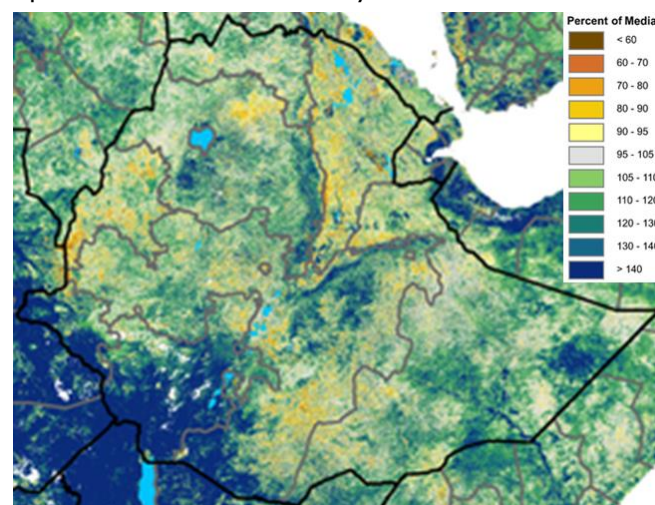
Despite the near average *Meher* harvest, on average national staple food prices are unseasonably increasing even in some surplus-producing areas of the country. Typically, after the *Meher* harvest, prices significantly decrease. Staple prices in some markets are following seasonal trends decreasing from a peak in October; however, continue to remain above the five-year average. Prices are above average, especially in eastern parts of the country, as the result increased transportation costs, insecurity restricting domestic trade from surplus western areas to eastern parts of the country, and high inflation rate. According to Ethiopian Trade and Business Corporation (ETBC), maize prices in Hosanna market (a surplus southern producing market, Figure 4) peaked in October and have slowly declined through December. However, December 2019 maize grain prices were 16 and 21 percent above the same time last year and five-year average respectively. Maize prices in Dire Dawa, in eastern Ethiopia and Addis Ababa Central market, were nearly 60 and 70

Figure 2. CHIRPS rainfall ranking of October -December 2019 period compared to the historical record since 1981



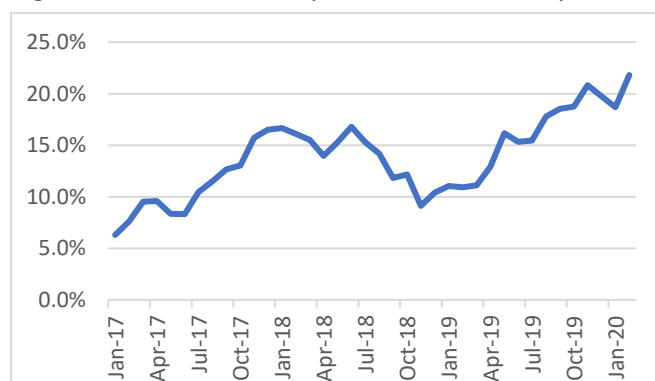
Source: FEWS NET/UCSB CHC

Figure 3. Normalized Difference Vegetation Index (NDVI) as a percent of median for February 21 to 29, 2020



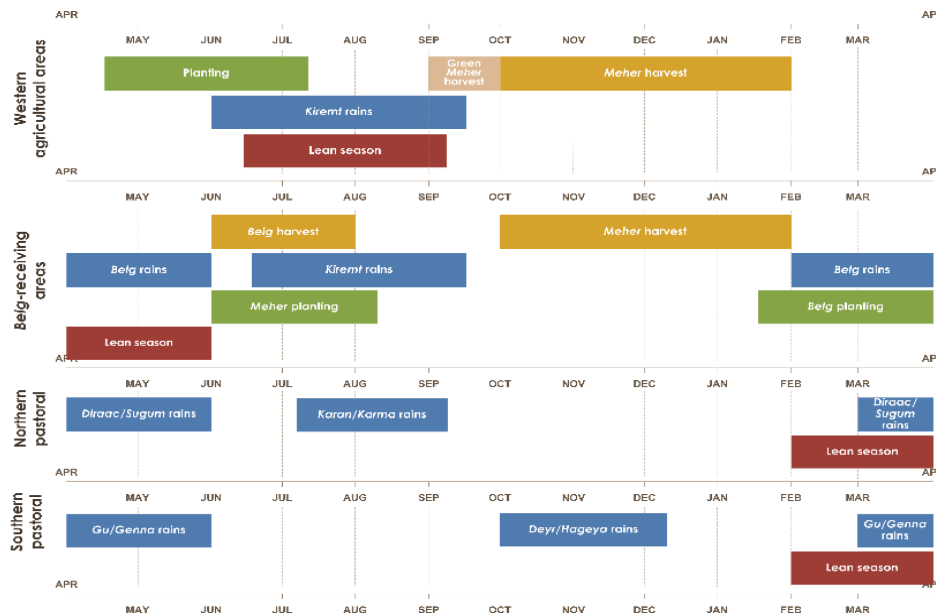
Source: USGS/FEWS NET

Figure 3. Inflation rate for September 2017 to February 2020



Source: Central Statistics Authority (CSA)

SEASONAL CALENDAR FOR A TYPICAL YEAR

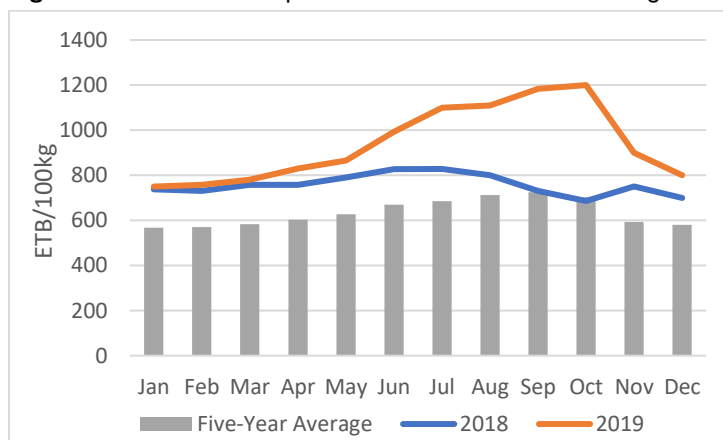


Source: FEWS NET

percent above the same time last year, respectively. In both, these market prices were 100 percent above the five-year average.

Livestock prices across the country have also increased; however, they are increasing at a slower rate than staple foods. This has negatively affected some pastoral household's purchasing power. Although in some pastoral areas of Somali Region, livestock and staple food prices increases are generally following a similar trend, which is having little impact on household purchasing power. With seasonally low income from agriculture activities and a decline in income from casual labor, households are currently unable to generate enough income to purchase food to meet all their food needs. In most pastoral and agropastoral areas this is forcing households to atypically sell livestock. In northern pastoral areas, livestock prices are not increasing at a similar rate as staple food prices. As a result, purchasing power is continuously decreasing in northern pastoral households.

Figure 4. Wholesale Maize prices in Hosana Market in ETB/100kg



Source: ETBC

The current behavior of agriculture and non-agricultural labor opportunities across the country is highly influenced by the agricultural season and security situation. Since it is the dry season in most parts of the country and insecurity is increasing, labor opportunities for the poor remain below average.

According to the IOM Round 20 (collected in November to December 2019) National Displacement Report, released in February 2020, over 1.7 million people were identified as displaced in nearly 1,200 sites. IOM found the biggest cause for displacement was conflict, resulting in nearly 1.15 million Internally Displaced People (IDPs). The rest of the IDPs were due to drought and seasonal flooding. According to UNHCR, there have been more than 370,000 new displacements since November 2019, across areas of the country. These populations have been displaced as the result of conflict. The highest rate of displacement is taking place in Somali and Oromia Regions.

An Inter-agency Multi-Sectoral Rapid Needs Assessment report of IDPs in Guji Zone in the Oromia Region, in late December 2019 found that nearly 68,000 people, about 22 percent of the general population had been displaced (Figure 4). This is due to conflict between state and non-state actors. As the result of ongoing conflict, many of these populations have not returned

to their place of origin. As per the same report, IDPs and host communities have yet to receive assistance and the situation is exacerbated by the high levels of malnutrition among children, the elderly, and PLW.

PSNP resources are typically distributed between January and June 2020 for public works projects and direct support to about 8 million people throughout the country. PSNP distribution started for 2020; however, based on historical trends distribution is expected to be irregular and has not started in all areas of the country.

In 2020, the Government of Ethiopia and the international community through the Humanitarian Response Plan (HRP) identified 6.4 million people in need of humanitarian assistance. Out of the total population in need per the HRP, 5.9 million people are targeted for in-kind emergency food or cash assistance. This assistance is expected to be distributed in seven rounds. As per the prioritization committee (PC) analysis, there are significant carry-over resources that are expected to be used for distribution for the 2020 HRP. Humanitarian food distribution for 2020 has started in some areas of the country.

National therapeutic feeding program (TFP) admission data from the Emergency Nutrition Coordination Unit (ENCU) for September to November 2019 indicate a decline in the number of admissions; however, TFP admissions remain above last year and the five-year average. It is anticipated that the prevalence of wasting will continue to decrease through February 2020 and start worsening at the peak of the lean season.

Western and central surplus producing areas of the country are in Minimal (IPC Phase 1) as these households continue to consume own foods. Food security is stable in most parts of the Southern Nations Nationalities and People Region (SNNPR), following the average *Meher* and *Belg* harvests in 2019 production, with Minimal (IPC Phase 1) outcomes present in the western part of the region. However, in eastern parts of SNNPR bordering Oromia, and western areas of Somali Region bordering Oromia Region, conflict has negatively impacted household access to normal livelihoods. Additionally, households in these areas have exhausted their own produced foods, have limited access to markets, and/or have limited ability to access income from livestock and livestock products. As a result, much of these areas face Crisis (IPC Phase 3) and Stressed (IPC Phase 2), or in some isolated areas Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!) as humanitarian food assistance is improving food access.

Most households including *Belg* producing areas in northeastern Amhara and Tigray Regions, areas along the Tekeze river and Waghimera Zone of Amhara, and eastern Oromia Region, particularly in East and West Hararghe Zones, and the lowlands of Arsi and Bale, bordering Somali region and those conflict-affected households in Gedio Zone of SNNPR have exhausted their stock from own production and have below-average market access to food. As a result, these areas are mostly in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) or Stressed (IPC Phase 2). Some areas which are receiving humanitarian food assistance are in Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!).

In addition to conflict, the high concentration of livestock in specific areas due to insecurity, impacts from desert locust infestations, and high staple food prices is resulting in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) or Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!) among poor households in much of Somali Region.

Some parts of Afar and northern Somali Region food security outcomes remain stable with Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!) and Minimal (IPC Phase 1) ongoing due to late and unseasonable 2019 *Kiremt* rainfall. However, due to the consecutive poor seasons in northern Afar, Crisis (IPC Phase 3) and Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!) outcomes are present.

Assumptions

The most likely scenario from February to September 2020 is based on the following national-level assumptions:

- The February to May *Belg* rainfall season is expected to be average; however, in northeastern parts of *belg* receiving areas, there is a slight tendency for rainfall to be average to below average.
- *Gu/Genna*/long rains (March to May) are likely to be average.
- The *Sugum* (March to May) in northern pastoral areas is expected to be average; however, in southern parts of this area, there is a tendency for average to below-average rainfall.

Figure 5. Estimated number of new IDPs in Guji zone of Oromia

Woreda	Number of new IDPs	Kebeles with IDPs
Liben	17,600	7
Gorodola	21,400	7
Sebaboru	24,000	8
Agawayu	3,250	6
Gumi-Eldelo	13,000	6
Total	79,250	28

Source: Inter-agency Multi-Sectoral Rapid Needs Assessment report

- *Kiremt/Karma/Karan* rains between June and September 2020 are likely to be average.
- In eastern and northeastern parts of the country due to the tendency for below-average rainfall and above normal temperatures, there are expected to be some negative impacts on pasture and crop performance.
- *Belg* land preparation, planting, and production is expected to be generally near normal with the expected average rainfall. However, some localized crop losses are expected in some *Belg* producing areas of the Rift Valley and central Ethiopia.
- Control measures for desert locusts are expected to continue at the local and national levels; however, they will most likely be insufficient to limit the outbreak and insecurity is likely to limit control operations in parts of the country.
- Given forecast for average March to May 2020 *Gu/Ganna* rains this will most likely lead to average pasture and water regeneration. However, winds, soil moisture, and vegetation are currently favorable for desert locust breeding. According to FAO's February Locust Watch, desert locusts will likely continue to breed and spread through June 2020. Given the life cycle of desert locusts and the March to May start of the long rains season coinciding with the regeneration of rangeland and the start of planting activities, this will likely enable a new wave of breeding and further spread in March and April. This is expected to result in localized crop and pasture losses in agropastoral and pastoral areas of eastern areas of the country.
- In southern and southeastern pastoral areas, the anticipated average *Gu/Genna* rainfall between March and May is likely to lead to average pasture and water regeneration, which is expected to facilitate normal grazing and drinking for livestock during the dry season between June and September. However, areas worst-affected by desert locusts are expected to have a high rate of decline in pasture availability after the *Gu* as desert locusts are expected to consume pasture.
- In northern pastoral areas of Afar and northern Somali Regions, the anticipated average *Sugum/Gu/Genna* and *Karam/Karan* rains will help to improve pasture and water availability. However, warmer than normal climate will have impacts on the long-term pasture and water availability in northeastern parts of the country.
- The expected average *Sugum/Gu/Genna* and *Karam/Karan* rains in northern, southern, and southeastern pastoral areas will most likely improve livestock body conditions, production, and productivity to normal due to the availability of crop residue and expected increases in pasture and water with seasonal increases. However, in some localized northern, southern, and southeastern pastoral areas, improvements in livestock body conditions following these rains are likely to be temporary due to consumption of vegetation by desert locusts and the anticipated restriction of movement due to insecurity and the desert locust invasion. In areas affected by desert locusts, while favorable rainfall will likely mitigate pasture losses, atypical pasture deterioration is likely during the June to September dry season and is expected to lead to some atypical livestock migration. As a result, some deterioration in livestock body conditions is expected; however, no atypical livestock deaths are anticipated.
- There is a high likelihood of livestock disease, particularly an outbreak of Rift Valley Fever (RVF) in flood-prone areas of the rift valley and southern pastoral areas.
- Agricultural labor opportunities between February and June 2020 are likely to be normal. Although, due to the anticipated atypically high number of people in search of labor, below-average wage rates are likely in *Belg*-producing areas of SNNPR, Amhara, and central and eastern Oromia. Although, in most parts of Amhara, Tigray, and central Oromia labor availability is expected to have seasonal improvements; however, remains below average, from June to September 2020.
- Household income from non-agriculture labor is expected to be normal in most parts of crop dependent areas; however, wage rates are likely to be below average in comparison to the increasing cost of living.
- Supplies of staple cereals on markets are expected to remain at seasonally normal levels in most parts of Amhara, Tigray, and Oromia, following the average *Meher* 2019 harvest in most major cereal-producing areas of the country. However, staple cereals market prices are expected to remain above average and increase throughout the scenario period as the ETB continues to depreciate and its purchasing capacity deteriorates as the inflation rate is expected to remain high.
- Livestock prices are expected to be average to above average in many areas due to improved livestock body condition and the devaluation of the ETB. However, in lowland woredas along the Tekeze catchment of Amhara and Tigray Regions,

and northern parts of Afar, livestock prices anticipated to follow a decreasing trend following the expected poor body condition as *Belg* rains in these areas are likely to be below average.

- The National Electoral Board of Ethiopia (NEBE) plans to hold a national general election in August 2020. Based on historical trends of ethnic intolerance, violence in recent years, and an increase of insecurity prior to and after elections, an increase in conflict is expected leading up to the elections. As a result, displacement and disruption of livelihoods are anticipated to increase around the time of the elections. An increase in conflict and displacement are expected to be the highest, along the Oromia and Somali, southern Afar and Amhara, SNNPR and Oromia, and Beneshangul-Gumuz and Amhara borders. Additionally, the conflict is expected to lead to the denial of access to affected communities by humanitarian actors, disruption of domestic trade and market supply, and a temporary high increase of staple food and nonfood prices where conflict disrupts market activities.
- In mid-November, the Sidama people of the Sidama Zone in SNNPR voted in favor of independent statehood and the referendum was considered as peaceful. However, issues related to border demarcation, retaliation and discrimination against minorities, and the power competition of different parties coupled with the upcoming election is likely to trigger further displacement and collapse of livelihoods of more people in this area.
- Based on historical nutrition survey and TFP admission trend data, levels of acute malnutrition vary by season where higher levels of acute malnutrition are recorded in the main hunger season (May to September) particularly in *Meher*-dependent areas. As such, TFP admissions are likely to increase between May and September mostly in *Meher*-dependent areas. In parts of East and West Hararghe, Dire Dawa, lowlands of Bale, Afar, and parts of Somali region, reported disease outbreaks including cholera, measles, and chikungunya are anticipated to persist contributing to further deterioration of acute malnutrition.
- PSNP resources are planned, funded, and likely to be transferred to about 8 million chronically food insecure people in eight regions of the country for six months between January and June 2020 on a regular basis.
- The HRP has planned for approximately 5.9 million people between January and June 2020 to receive emergency food and non-food assistance. However, humanitarian assistance distribution is anticipated to remain irregular. Plans for humanitarian food assistance for the June to September period were not available for this analysis, as such the analysis for the June to September period does not include the impacts of humanitarian food assistance.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

In Eastern Tigray and Amhara, East and West Hararghe of Oromia, and Burj and Amaro Zones of SNNPR *Meher* production was well below average and household food stocks are not expected to last through the February to March period. As a result, poor households will most likely start facing difficulties addressing their minimal food needs starting in February or March. Moreover, pastoral and agro-pastoral areas of northern Afar, Bale, Guji and Borena lowlands of Oromia Region, South Omo of SNNPR, and Warder, Shabelle and Liben Zones of Somali Region due to conflict-related displacements and concentration of livestock in specific areas due to insecurity, desert locust infestations, and high staple food prices, poor households in these parts of the country will be either Crisis (IPC Phase 3) or Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!) from February to May 2020. Stressed (IPC Phase 2) outcomes in other southern and southeastern pastoral areas as livestock conditions are expected to continue to be average; however, herd sizes are still below average.

Access to own-produced crops is likely to improve somewhat in *Belg*-producing areas starting in June, whereas most poor households in *Meher*-dependent areas will face food consumption gaps as they move to their peak of the lean season between June to September 2020. In the western and central surplus-producing areas of the country, the average *Meher* harvest will most likely seasonally improve food consumption and income-earning from harvest labor.

The largest number of people in need of humanitarian food assistance is expected to be in the eastern part of the country during the peak lean season for *Meher*-dependent areas and areas worst affected by conflict due to the elections from June to September 2020. Despite the generally favorable June to September *Kiremt/Karan/Karma* and March to April *Gu/Genna* rains in the pastoral areas of the country, Crisis (IPC Phase 3) and Stressed (IPC Phase 2) outcomes are expected in much of these areas due to asset depletion caused by the cumulative effects of repeated droughts, conflict, flood, and pest infestations.

Events that Might Change the Outlook

Possible events over the next eight months that could change the most-likely scenario.

Area	Event	Impact on food security outcomes
<i>Belg</i> -producing areas	A late start and/or below-average <i>Belg</i> rains from February to May 2020	The area planted under long-cycle crops would be below-average, reducing <i>Belg</i> and long-cycle <i>Meher</i> crops, increasing demand on markets and decreasing labor demand associated.
Pastoral areas	A late start and/or below-average amount of <i>Belg</i> rains from February to May 2020 and <i>Kiremt</i> rains from June to September 2020	Livestock body conditions would deteriorate, and productivity would decline. Reduced milk production and reduced income from livestock sales would likely follow.
Nationwide	Desert locust infestation is not controlled and agroclimatic conditions favor locusts.	Both long and short cycle crops and pasture would be devastated and reduced both <i>Belg</i> and <i>Meher</i> production and livestock body condition. Increasing the areas in Crisis (IPC Phase 3).
Nationwide	Long -term conflict across the country associated with the upcoming election	Livelihood activities would be obstructed, income from livelihood activities would be declined and loss of life and livelihoods

AREAS OF CONCERN

Shabelle Riverine (SHR) Livelihood Zone

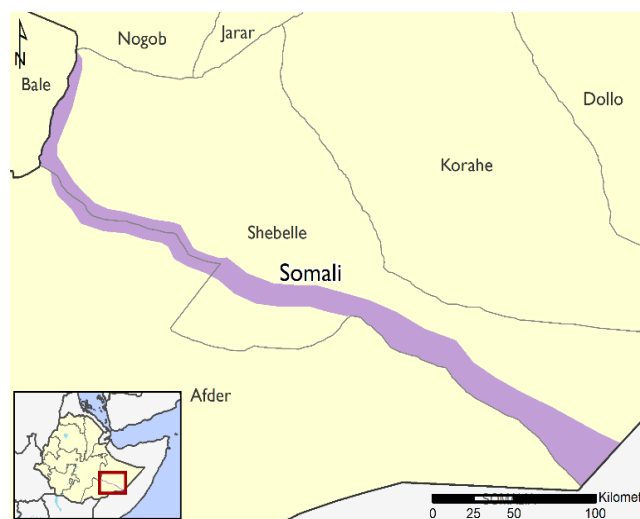
Current Situation

The 2019 October to December *Deyr* was significantly above average. Based on both satellite rainfall estimates and interviews during a FEWS NET field assessment, confirm this led to favorable conditions for most agropastoral areas and surrounding pastoral areas. The moisture available from *Deyr* 2019 (October to December) rainy season significantly improved pasture, browse, and water availability in this livelihood zone. However, due to the above-average rain, flooding occurred, specifically along the Shebelle River. Typically, the Shebelle River floods 2 to 3 times during the *Deyr*; however, this year flooding occurred almost at double this level and was more widespread. The flooding damaged irrigation farmland and seasonal crops cultivated in recession farming areas. Many households had to plant multiple times with some households not able to re-plant due to lack of access to agriculture inputs. As such, there are some households that did not plant crops at all. Flooding also delayed agricultural labor activities. Based on field assessments and information gathered from key informants, production is estimated to be 53 percent lower compared to that of the reference year in the livelihood zone baselines. Livestock losses as the result of flooding were minimal.

Additionally, since June 2019, desert locusts have invaded this area. According to FAO in January, desert locusts cover about 64 km² in Somali region, which holds an estimated 3.2 billion locusts. Escapée swarms from the breeding sites have invaded more areas where they attacked green vegetation including standing crops like onion and sorghum, pasture fields, and ground cover. Community members reported that desert locusts had been seen about three times from the start of the 2019 *Deyr*. The interviewed communities also indicated that crop and pasture damage was minimal and that most ongoing control measures are traditional, and no formal large-scale measures are ongoing.

The number of milking cows during the 2019 *Deyr* season is below average due to lower rates of cattle births during the 2019 *Jalal* (February/March 2019). There were also few cattle birth in October 2019 due to low conception nine months earlier. Despite improved milk per animal, total milk production remains below average as the number of milking animals is about half of the reference year, according to field assessments and key informant interviews. The frequent impact of drought in the previous years, livestock holdings are about 60 percent of the reference year.

Figure 6. Area of concern map identifying livelihood zone SHR



Source: FEWS NET

Livestock supply in main markets remains below average as livestock holdings are below average. The improved livestock body conditions and low supply on the market has resulted in increases in livestock prices. Similarly, staple food prices have increased due to the decline of grain supply from the local harvest and from the central and western surplus producing areas due to high transportation costs related to civil unrest. As a result, staple food prices are significantly above average. In Gode market, the price of the 50 kg maize and average size local goat in January 2020 was 700 and 1450 ETB, respectively. This is 56 and 60, and 12 and 136 percent higher than in January 2019 and the five-year average, respectively. The price increase of livestock is higher than the price increase of staple food prices. As a result, the goat-to-maize Terms of Trade (ToT), in January 2020 was 28 percent higher than the same month last year but 48 percent lower than the five-year average (Figure 7).

The total TFP admissions since June 2019 is much higher than last year and the five-year average. According to the data from the regional ENCU, the total TFP admission in November in Somali region is about 20 and 143 percent higher than the same month last year and last five-year average in Kelafo and Mustahil Woredas in Shebelle Zone, respectively. There were no atypical disease outbreaks in any other part of the region, except the confirmed cases of cholera in Kelafo where the outbreak started in early January 2020. The cases are decreasing due to effective measures taken by regional and zonal health offices.

The PSNP resource transfer started in January in some areas for public work beneficiaries at a rate of 41 Birr/person/day and expected to continue to the end of June 2020. According to the 2020 HRP, about 1.74 million people are targeted in Somali region for assistance in 2020. Out of the total number of beneficiaries, 53 percent are the conflict-related IDPs.

Despite improved daily milk production and livestock body conditions, the overall below average livestock holdings and the below average harvest, household incomes are below average. The continuous increase in staple food prices is significantly decreasing poor and very poor household's purchasing power. Though, humanitarian food aid assistance distributed in the areas is helping to protect food consumption gaps. Based on the results of a Households Economy Approach (HEA) outcome analysis, most parts of Shebelle, Warder, Leben, and Korahe areas have are currently in Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!).

Assumptions

In addition to the national-level assumptions described above, the following area-level assumptions have been used to develop the most likely scenario for Shabelle Riverine (SHR) Livelihood Zone:

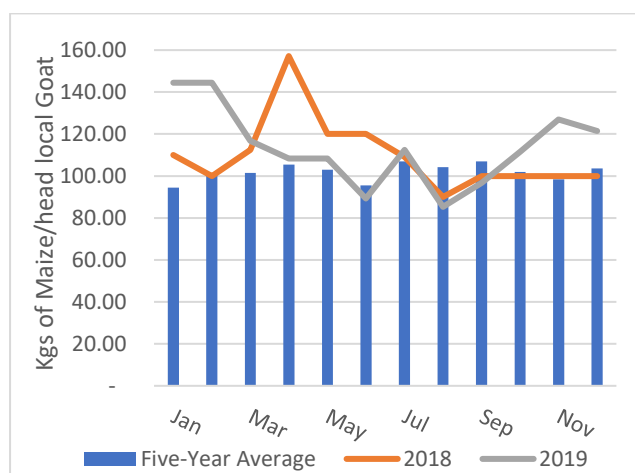
- As births of livestock are expected to remain below average, due to the smaller number of camel and cattle conceived the 2019 *Gu*, the number of the milking animals and milk availability will be much below normal in this scenario period.
- As households herd size and the subsequent livestock birth and milk production are not expected to recover to normal levels, gift and social support are expected to be below average as well as herd sizes and milk production.

Most Likely Food Security Outcome

According to field assessments and results of a HEA outcome analysis including PSNP and humanitarian food assistance, the total annual survival deficit of poor and very poor households contributing to 41 percent of the total population in the LZ, is about 10 percent. Thus, poor household's purchasing power is expected to continue to be limited due to a smaller number of sellable livestock as herd sizes are below normal associated with the consecutive poor seasonal performance in the past. Therefore, poor households in the lowlands of the livelihood zone are currently in Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!) only with the ongoing humanitarian assistance from February to May 2020.

The anticipated average March to May 2020 *Gu* rainfall is likely to improve livestock body conditions, production, and productivity. As such, milk production will improve significantly per animal to supplement household food consumption between April and June 2020. However, only a few animals for milking will be lactating during the March to May 2020 period. In addition, with the normal dry period between July and September, milk availability will further decline following normal

Figure 7. Goat-to-maize terms of trade in Gode Market



Source: SDPPC

seasonal patterns. Therefore, most poor and very poor households in these areas are expected to be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) during the June to September 2020 period.

Tekeze Lowland Sorghum and Goats (TSG)/Waghimra and North Gondar Zones of Amhara

Current Situation

Based on remote-sensing products as well as key informants, 2019 *Kiremt* rainfall was poor with the largest portion of seasonal rainfall totals falling within a few days. Despite late seasonal rainfall across much of the country key informants indicated limited late-season rainfall occurred in this area. The zonal *Meher* assessment report indicates the harvest is estimated to be about 50 percent of normal with the largest production deficits in the lowland woredas of Sehala and Ziquala where production was about 5 and 10 percent of the plan, respectively.

Households are struggling to feed their livestock with crop residues and pasture, as such livestock have atypically migrated to areas with better pasture. As a result, livestock body conditions and milk production are poor. It is also evident households are atypically selling their livestock attempting to avoid the risk of further body condition decline and price reduction.

Local staple cereal supply is limited, with sorghum in the markets originating from western areas, which is further raising prices as geographic proximity, security, and transportation infrastructure are the main constraints. Sorghum prices have been increasing at atypically high rates and in December 2019 reaching their highest point in the last five years. Price data from the Zonal Disaster Risk Management (DRM) office in December 2019 estimated the price of sorghum to be 1,800 ETB per 100 kg. This is 2 percent higher than December 2018, although nearly 65 percent higher than the five-year average.

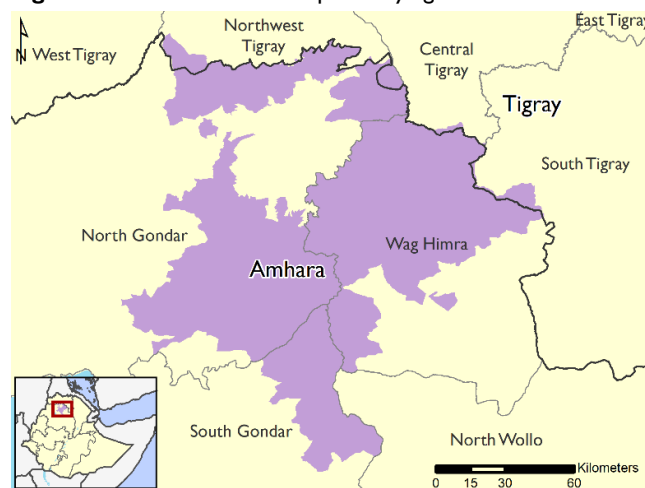
Similarly, livestock prices continue to escalate as demand for livestock is increasing in urban markets; however, livestock prices are not increasing at the same rate as staple grains. The Waghimra DRM office reported the December 2019 goat prices were 10 and 82 percent (2,200 ETB) above last year and the five-year average, respectively. The goat to sorghum ToT in the recent months exhibited a slight decline but its long-term trend showed a significant drop as the price of staple cereals rises much faster than that of goat prices.

The Zonal Office of Health reported over 7,300 people had confirmed cases of malaria since September 2019 in Waghimra Zone. 90 percent of the cases are reported within TSG livelihood zone. The malaria outbreak continued through at least February; however, since the dry season has started the number of malaria cases has been decreasing. Additionally, there is a scabies outbreak in Waghimera with over 2,200 people affected at the zonal level in October 2019. These outbreaks have contributed along with food insecurity to the likely deterioration of nutrition outcomes in this livelihood zone. Despite the continuous distribution of therapeutic foods for the treatment of Moderately Acute Malnutrition (MAM) in children under five years of age and PLW, the number of admissions to OTP increased between November and December 2019 (Figure 8).

PSNP has reached slightly over 150,000 beneficiaries through public work (PW) or direct support (DS) programming.

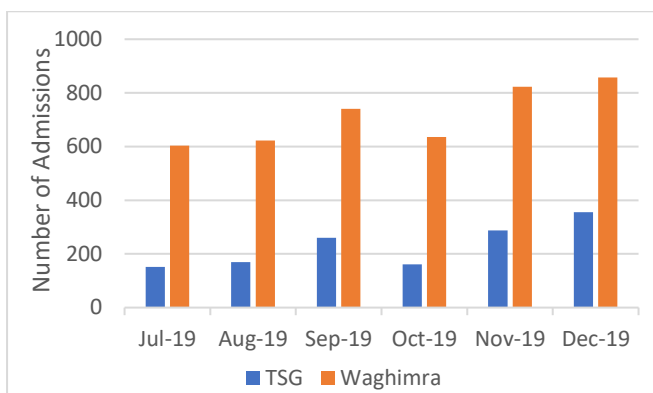
Humanitarian food assistance distribution was ongoing during the January 2020 FEWS NET field assessment. At this time, an estimated 63,500 beneficiaries received 3 rounds and 126,000 had received 2 rounds of assistance. The major items included in the relief basket are 15 kg of grain (wheat), 1.5kg of yellow split peas, and 0.45kg of vegetable oil.

Figure 8. Area of concern map identifying livelihood zone TSG



Source: FEWS NET

Figure 8. Number of Admissions to TSP in Waghimra for July 2019 to December 2019



Source: ENCU

The major drivers for the food insecurity are attributed to below average, delayed performance, and early withdraw of the 2019 *Kiremt* season, which led to a significantly below-average harvest. Despite the meager 2019 *Meher* harvest in the livelihood zone (LZ) and the surrounding areas, prices of staple food crops were stable, although well above average. Households are reliant on markets for food with below-average incomes. Based on results from a FEWS NET HEA outcome analysis carried out in January, poor and very poor households had an annual survival deficit of nearly 20 percent. However, due to humanitarian assistance across much of this area, many households are in Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!), with a few areas not receiving significant assistance in Crisis (IPC Phase 3).

Assumptions

The assumptions in the national overview described above were used to develop the most likely scenario for Tekeze Lowland Sorghum and Goats (TSG)/Waghimra and North Gondar Zones of Amhara.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Food available from own production is expected to be limited to none with many households most likely relying on labor and selling of livestock to access income for market purchases. Households mainly are expected to rely on humanitarian food assistance, market purchase from cash income obtained from the sale of livestock, and labor employment. Though labor wage rates are unlikely to decline, labor employment is likely to be impaired due to the restricted movement of people in the aftermath of the election and other ethnic related conflict threats. On the contrary, staple food prices are likely to escalate as the insecurity, increased demand, and lower supply are expected to drive soaring prices.

Results of a FEWS NET HEA outcome analysis for TSG indicate, very poor and poor households are expected to be facing an estimated survival deficit of nearly 20 percent annually. Households are expected to face increasing food consumption gaps and areas not receiving humanitarian food assistance are expected to be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3). Although, Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!) are anticipated in areas receiving significant humanitarian food assistance from February to May 2020.

Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes are expected to emerge across the entire livelihood zone in June to September 2020 as there are currently no plans for likely and funded humanitarian food assistance.

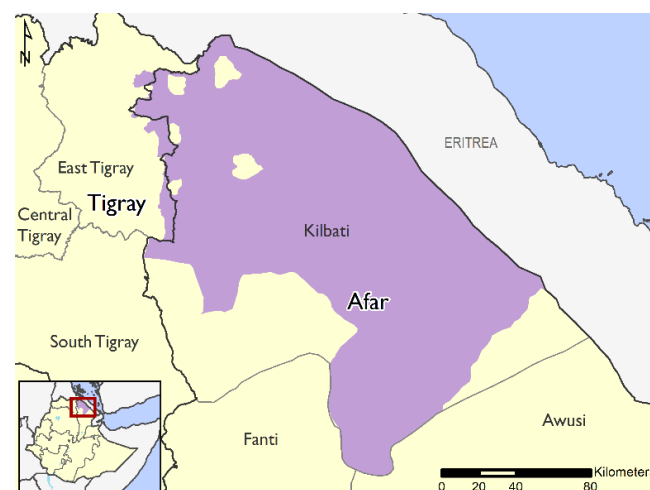
Asale Pastoral Livelihood Zone (ASP)

Current Situation

This area experienced its third consecutive year of poor rainfall from July to September 2019 as the 2019 *Karma* rainy season was delayed by a month and poorly performed. However, unseasonal rainfall in October/November 2019 helped improve pasture and water conditions for the short-term. This rainfall improved rainfall deficits, pasture conditions, and livestock body conditions. Although, the 'Deda', which is a very short five to ten-day period of rain in January, did not occur. By February 2020 most of the pasture was minimal. Based on focus group discussions from FEWS NET field assessments, grazing lands did not fully regenerate.

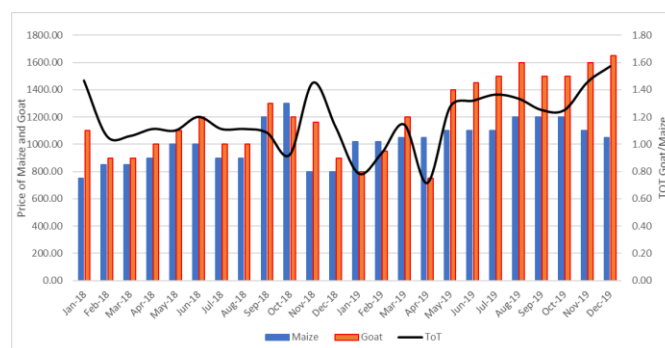
Currently, livestock body conditions, production, and productivity are near normal. According to key informants, some areas within Koneba and Berhale woredas do not have pasture and browse available. Thus, some households have migrated their

Figure 9. Area of concern map identifying livelihood zone ASP



Source: FEWS NET

Figure 10. Abala Woreda maize-to-goat terms of trade for August 2016 to December 2019



Source: Afar region and Abala woreda DPPD

camels and goats atypically early to nearby valleys and hillsides bordering Tigray region with relatively better pasture. However, in other parts of the livelihood zone, livestock feed availability is relatively better and there are no reports of atypical livestock movements.

Maize grain prices atypically increased by almost 25 percent between December 2019 to January 2020 as market supply atypically decreased as more households relying on the market for food. According to information gathered during FEWS NET's field assessment, the market maize supply shrunk due to a decrease in supply from neighboring areas of Tigray and Amhara. This is the result of the below-average 2019 *Meher* production in some areas, road closures, sporadic conflict, and inflation.

Generally, livestock supply on the market is relatively stable; however, prices are atypically increasing. This is mostly resulting from an increase in demand for meat during the holidays at the start of 2020. The Afar Region DPPB indicated that goat prices in January 2020 were 1,700 ETB, which is 113 and 121 percent above the same time last year and the five-year average, respectively. In addition to the holidays, the prices are increasing due to the increase in the cost of living and high inflation. The ToT for livestock to maize grain favors pastoralists; however, due to the recurrent poor seasons, herd sizes are below average (Figure 10). Some poor and very poor households have limited livestock holdings and limited ability to access income from this source.

TFP admissions have increased throughout 2019 with the highest number of admissions in October through December. The increased admission rate is the result of various factors including limited food access, and outbreaks of AWD, measles, malaria and Chikungunya disease. At the regional level, in December 2019 the number of TFP admissions increased by about 1.5 percent from November to December 2019, nearly a 40 percent increase from the same time last year.

According to the Afar region DPPD, about 101,000 and 167,000 people are targeted for emergency and PSNP assistance in Zone 2, respectively. As of early February 2020, both the emergency and PSNP resources were being prepared for distribution.

Poorer household has limited food access due to below-average income; however, are trying to partially access their minimum food needs by selling livestock and accessing social support, and remittances, and humanitarian assistance. Thus, poorer households in the ASP livelihood zone are currently facing food consumption gaps and are in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) or Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!).

Assumptions

In addition to the national-level assumptions described above, the following area-level assumptions have been used to develop the most likely scenario for Asale Pastoral Livelihood Zone:

- With the anticipated average tending to below-average *Sugum* rain, pasture conditions are not expected to improve. Livestock body conditions are not expected to improve with the limited availability of pasture. Moreover, milk production and livestock productivity are expected to remain below average due to the small herd sizes and scarce pasture. Additionally, due to the consecutive poor seasons, a low birth rate of camels and goats is expected.
- Around Awash riverine areas, crop production is expected to be average. Additionally, during the anticipated *Karma* season, *Meher* agricultural activities are expected to be normal in the agro-pastoral areas. However, the expectation of Fall Armyworm and Desert Locusts, and excess flash flood damage along with major riverine and sedentary farming areas, is likely to lead to localized areas of below-average production.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Most poor households will face constrained milk access from livestock and rely on markets to fulfill their food and non-food needs. Moreover, the prevailing high staple food prices combined with low livestock holdings are expected to decrease household's purchasing capacity. Poor and very poor households are likely to face difficulty meeting all of their food needs. Based on HEA Outcome Analysis and with the expectation of some areas receiving significant humanitarian food assistance Stressed! (IPC Phase 2!) between February and May 2020 are expected across most of this livelihood zone.

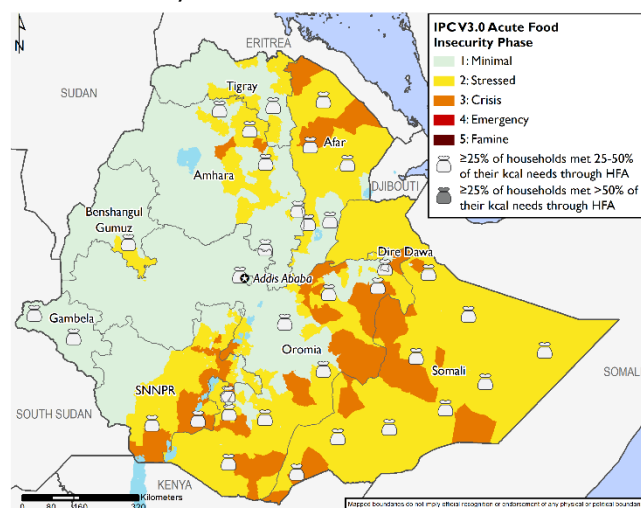
Pasture regeneration and water replenishment is expected to start following the anticipated average July to September 2020 *Karma* rainy season. This is expected to moderately improve livestock body conditions and productivity. As the number of camels and goats conceived during the July to September 2019 *Karma* was very low; reproduction, production, and productivity of camels and goats are not expected to much improve. Although, livestock prices are expected to gradually improve with the slight improvement of the body condition. Additionally, during the June to September 2020 period, staple food prices are expected to continue to atypically increase due to the peak of the lean season elsewhere in the country. As a

result of HEA outcome analysis, poor households are expected to face significant food consumption gaps that will continue in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) during June to September 2020 scenario period.

MOST LIKELY FOOD SECURITY OUTCOMES AND AREAS RECEIVING SIGNIFICANT LEVELS OF HUMANITARIAN ASSISTANCE

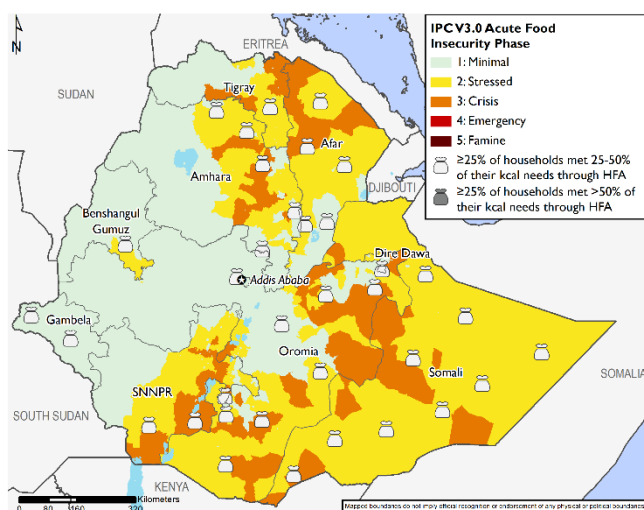
Each of these maps adheres to IPC v3.0 humanitarian assistance mapping protocols and flags where significant levels of humanitarian assistance are being/are expected to be provided. 🍲 indicates that at least 25 percent of households receive on average 25–50 percent of caloric needs from humanitarian food assistance (HFA). 🍲 indicates that at least 25 percent of households receive on average over 50 percent of caloric needs through HFA. This mapping protocol differs from the (!) protocol used in the maps at the top of the report. The use of (!) indicates areas that would likely be at least one phase worse in the absence of current or programmed humanitarian assistance.

Current, February 2020



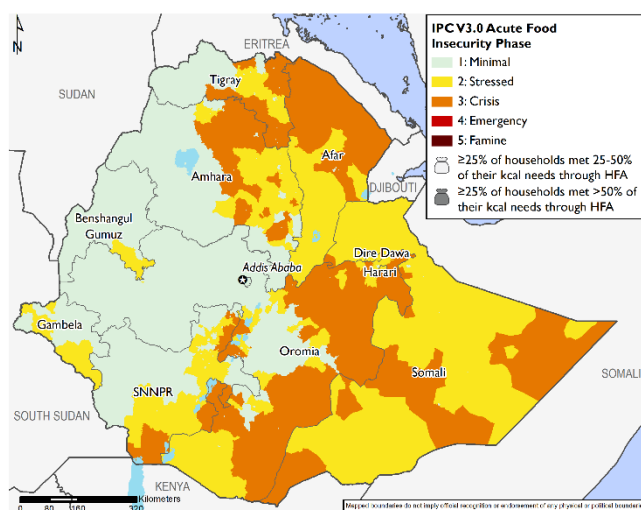
Source: FEWS NET

Projected food security outcomes, February to May 2020



Source: FEWS NET

Projected food security outcomes, June to September 2020



Source: FEWS NET

FEWS NET classification is IPC-compatible. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners.

ABOUT SCENARIO DEVELOPMENT

To project food security outcomes, FEWS NET develops a set of assumptions about likely events, their effects, and the probable responses of various actors. FEWS NET analyzes these assumptions in the context of current conditions and local livelihoods to arrive at a most likely scenario for the coming eight months. [Learn more here.](#)